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DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA

'NEW EV POLICY EMPOWERS MIDDLE CLASS'

'Delhi transforming... has chosen a new direction for cleaner, more modern future'

'Subsidies not capped... total incentive around Rs 60,000-70,000 per vehicle'

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, July 4

The Capital's new Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy is not merely an incentive scheme, but a comprehensive roadmap to transform its transport ecosystem, reduce pollution and make electric mobility affordable, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said Saturday.

In an interview with *The Indian Express*, Gupta described the policy, which came into effect July 1, as "common-man centric" and one designed primarily for Delhi's middle class. The policy, she said, departs significantly from previous approaches by removing subsidy caps and focusing on the segments that contribute the most



to air pollution.

"We have given all kinds of possible incentives: Subsidy, scrapping incentive, road tax exemption and registration exemption," Gupta said.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Hafiz Saeed kin and aides among 23 added to terror list under UAPA, total count 80

Listing by Centre will help fight terror networks at national, international levels

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 4

THE CENTRE Saturday designated as terrorists 23 operatives of Pakistan-based terror organisations including Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) and Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT), citing their involvement in terror recruitment, infiltration, training, supply of arms through drones, and planning of attacks in Jammu and Kashmir.

This raises the total count of designated terrorists to 80. Fol-

lowing the amendment to the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967 (UAPA) by the Centre in 2019, 57 individuals had been designated as terrorists in 2024 under Section 35 of the Act and listed in its Fourth Schedule.

Among the 23 are the son-in-law of LeT founder Hafiz Muhammad Saeed and his close associates, three involved in the 2016 terror attack on an Army camp in Nagrota, and two involved in the 2018 terror attack on the Sunjwan Military Station.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

Biggest cities offer better salaries, more regular jobs for women, but stark gender disparity in income favours men

Women's overall contribution to workforce, however, continues to languish — just one of every four women employed in big cities compared to almost 3 of every 4 men

Zeeshan Shaikh
Mumbai, July 4

• JOBS AND SALARIES IN BIG CITIES

% employed in regular jobs

	MN-PLUS CITIES	URBAN INDIA
Men	56.4	46.5
Women	65.1	50.9
Overall	58.5	47.6

Average monthly salary

	MN-PLUS CITIES	URBAN INDIA
Men	Rs 30,707	Rs 27,984
Women	Rs 23,707	Rs 21,664
Overall	Rs 28,808	Rs 26,258

How metro cities pay

	MEN	WOMEN
Mumbai	Rs 36,453	Rs 35,788
Delhi	Rs 35,708	Rs 31,644
Bengaluru	Rs 37,430	Rs 28,325
Chennai	Rs 31,655	Rs 22,919
Kolkata	Rs 21,534	Rs 13,784

SOURCE: PERIODIC LABOUR FORCE SURVEY (PLFS) 2025

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 05~07~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

SAYS FEARMONGERS DID NOT SUCCEED

PM: Navigated energy crisis with India jalwa and hard work



PM Narendra Modi at an integrated refinery-cum-petrochemical complex in Rajasthan's Barmer, Saturday. PTI

'India has friendly ties, sourced fuel from over 40 countries during West Asia war'

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, July 4

UNDERLINING THAT his government took "every single step... sensitively, whether at the policy level or the diplomatic level" at the height of the West Asia crisis, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said Saturday that India successfully navigated one of the worst global energy crises by sourcing fuel from more than 40 countries, and credited it to friendly relations, diplomatic power, hard

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Shift in strategy

India's crude import strategy has shifted ever since the outbreak of hostilities in West Asia hit oil flows and increased freight risks. While Russian crude is still the backbone of India's import slate, refiners have diversified towards North American and Venezuelan barrels to offset the drop in supplies from the Gulf.

POLITICS PAGES 7, 6

PM WISHES TRUMP AS U.S. TURNS 250

JAISHANKAR LEAVES FOR WEST ASIA, U.S., EUROPE TOUR TODAY

• 24-YEAR-OLD MARINE ENGINEER FROM KERALA, ON HER FIRST SHIP DUTY, CAN'T FORGET THE SIGHT OF MISSILES STREAKING OVERHEAD

'Saw missiles for first time': For Paanch Saab, baptism by fire at sea near Hormuz

Sunanda Mehta
Pune, July 4

IN THE early hours of a tense morning outside the Strait of Hormuz, near the Fujairah anchorage, a young marine engineer from Kerala looked at the sky and saw missiles streak past, one after another. It lasted a few seconds but it was a sight, she says, she will never forget.

Hifa Salim (24) was just months into her dream job, having joined her very first ship in Houston in October 2025, when war broke out in the Persian Gulf, scrapping the ship's

planned cargo run to Kuwait in early March.

The vessel was instead directed to drift outside the Strait of Hormuz, near the Fujairah anchorage, and wait. Salim later learned that arriving in the area just 15 hours earlier would have trapped the vessel inside the strait when the situation really deteriorated.

It was on one of those drifting mornings, stepping onto the deck for fresh air before her engine room rounds, that she heard a sound from the sky and looked up to see the flashes.

"This was the first time I saw

missiles in real life. My hands started shivering," she says. Terrified, she ran below to the mess room and considered asking to sign off. But once there, she found her crewmates eating breakfast, laughing, entirely at ease and something in her perspective shifted.

"If my seniors could carry their own fear and still show up for work, so could I," says Salim.

She heard the main engine starting — a small kick ahead for position adjustment. "I heard the starting sound. 'Tak Tak Tak.' I hear that sound every time. But that morning it felt different. It felt like the heartbeat of the ship. And that time I real-



Hifa Salim (24) was just months into her dream job, having joined her very first ship, when war broke out in the Persian Gulf

ised the ship is alive. We are not alone," wrote Salim later in an essay published in the magazine of Synergy Marine Group that manages her ship.

She went down to have a cup of tea with the Second Engineer, the officer she reported to. "He took one look at me and could read that something is not right and when I said that I want to stay on board and be part of the team instead of quitting, he smiled and said in Malayalam, 'S saab ippo strong aayi, Vaa namuk oru fuel valve overhaul cheyyam, appo ellam sheryavuni' which translated to 'S saab had become strong now. Come, let's overhaul one fuel valve,

then everything will be alright.' In the middle of uncertainty, those simple words gave me comfort, strength and the confidence to carry on with my work."

As a fifth engineer everyone on board called her "Paanch Saab", the traditional title for the ship's youngest engineer. "I liked the name. It made me feel like I belonged, even though I didn't have a watch yet," says Salim who also made the decision to not tell her family at home the full extent of what was happening — she didn't want them to panic. It was only after the ship had safely cleared the area that she learned her parents had been doing the very same thing

for her: staying composed on their calls, masking their own fear so she wouldn't carry the weight of theirs.

"We were all trying to protect one another in our own way," she reflects.

Hailing from Edakkazhiyur, a small town in Thrissur district, her close-knit family had always taught her to dream big while staying grounded, she says. She had once dreamed of the Indian Navy, but the engineering side of the Merchant Navy pulled her in, partly because almost no one at home could tell her what the profession even involved.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Salaries and jobs

• WHERE WOMEN BEAT MEN

TOP SIX CITIES	WOMEN	GAP	MEN
Prayagraj	Rs 42,254	31%	Rs 32,214
Srinagar	Rs 33,869	24%	Rs 27,323
Lucknow	Rs 31,744	17%	Rs 27,098
Patna	Rs 31,013	11%	Rs 27,902
Meerut	Rs 20,057	5%	Rs 18,946
Varanasi	Rs 20,821	2%	Rs 20,331

stable jobs is stronger in cities with one million-plus population compared with urban India as a whole. Women also surpass men in such jobs by a notable margin, i.e., 65.1% of all employed women in million plus cities have a regular or salaried job compared with 56.4% all employed men.

Gender disparities in income, however, prevail in big cities as much or more than they do in urban India.

The report shows that women participation in regular or salaried jobs at 65.1% is also much stronger in 46 cities which have more than a million people as per Census 2011 compared with 50.9% in urban India.

While this is true, it is also a fact that women's worker population ratio (WPR) continues to languish. While men's WPR in million-plus cities is 72.6%, that for women is 25.5%. This is not very different from that of urban India, as a whole (73% for men, and 25.9% for women). WPR is the percentage of persons employed among the persons in the population.

There is a clear distinction in the employment trends of million-plus cities compared with urban India. Overall, regular or salaried jobs are markedly higher at 58.5% in these cities compared with 47.6% in urban India. Self-employed and casual jobs, put together, are higher at 52.4% in urban India compared with 41.4% jobs in million-plus cities. Jobs are divided in three categories: salaried or regular, self-employed, and casual.

In terms of income in regular jobs, while both men and women earn at least 10% more in million-plus cities compared with urban India, the income gap widens in the million-plus cities. Across urban India, men in regular salaried jobs earn an average Rs 27,984 a month against Rs 21,664 for women, a gap of Rs 6,320. In the country's 46 largest cities, the gap widens to Rs 7,000, with men earning an average Rs 30,707 a month compared to Rs 23,707 for women. Women salaries as a percentage of men's salaries is 77.2% both in million-plus cities and in urban India.

In a handful of cities, though, women have achieved near pay parity with men in regular salaried jobs. Prayagraj tops the list, where women earn 131.2% of male salaries (Rs 42,254 against Rs 32,214), followed by Srinagar at 124% (Rs 33,869 vs Rs 27,323), Lucknow at 117.1% (Rs 31,744 vs Rs 27,098), Patna at 111.1% (Rs 31,013 vs Rs 27,902), Meerut at 105.9% (Rs 20,057 vs Rs 18,946) and Varanasi at 102.4% (Rs 20,821 vs Rs 20,331).

The findings are part of the Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

PM on energy crisis

work and resolve.

Speaking in Rajasthan's Balthora after dedicating the country's first greenfield integrated refinery-cum-petrochemical complex to the nation at Pachpadra, Modi said, "Due to the war in West Asia, there was panic across the world. Every country was in distress. This war gave birth to the biggest energy crisis of the 21st century. Major nations are still grappling with fuel shortage today. But the willpower and efforts of the new India of the 21st century have prevailed over these challenges."

"During the war, India's friendship with other countries proved very useful. When this crisis began, India was importing fuel and energy from 25-26 countries. *Lekin sankat ke samay Bharat ki diplomacy kajaalwa dikh gaya; doosre deshon ke saath humare achche sambandh is sankat ki ghadi mein bahut kaam aaye* (But during this crisis, the power of India's diplomacy was demonstrated; our good relations

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The country didn't emerge from this unexpected challenge just like that; it was also due to the success of our visionary policies that have been going on for a decade," he said.

Attacking the previous Ashok Gehlot government in Rajasthan, Modi said: "Today, we are inaugurating the Rajasthan Refinery here. We signed an MoU for this in 2017. However, the Congress government ruled Rajasthan from 2018 to 2023. Due to the Congress's non-cooperation, work here virtually stalled. But as soon as the double-engine (BJP) government came to power, work progressed rapidly," he said.

"And you know my working style, whatever we lay the foundation stone for, we also inaugurate it. Similarly, India has steadily expanded its refinery capacity. The United States hasn't built a single new refinery in the last 50 years, and Europe's refinery capacity has steadily declined, while India today has the world's fourth-largest refinery capacity. And we are not going to stop there. This capacity is set to grow even further in the coming years," he said, adding

that it was due to such efforts that "India has emerged victorious from the biggest energy crisis of the century."

The country, he said, "took correct decisions at every stage: accurately assessed the crisis in a timely manner; devised an effective strategy; utilised the resources in a balanced way; and positively utilised Bharat's diplomatic power. Only then was Bharat able to emerge from the crisis."

"When certain forces were busy spreading rumours and apprehensions in the public sphere, the scale at which work was being carried out and the way the situation was being managed – that hard work, those efforts, and the patience involved were remarkable. Every single step was taken sensitively, whether at the policy level or the diplomatic level. And sooner or later, history will record that all of this was unprecedented," he said.

On the occasion, Modi also laid the foundation stone and inaugurated various development projects worth around Rs 1.06 lakh crore in Balotra, with the projects spanning multiple sectors including petrochemicals, urban transport, railways, roads, renewable energy, and power transmission.

Delhi CM

"Unlike other states, we have not put any capping. We want as many people as possible to avail the benefits of this EV policy so that the city's air improves."

Framing the policy as part of a broader transformation of the Capital, Gupta said, "Delhi is transforming. It has chosen a new direction – one focused on building a cleaner, more modern, and better future. The EV policy is also a part of this transformation and we believe it will usher in a new era of cleaner mobility."

Gupta said the policy deliberately prioritises electric two-wheelers and autorickshaws because the government believes they offer the quickest gains in reducing vehicular emissions.

"People wanted to switch to e-two-wheelers, but they could not do so because of the cost gap," she said, estimating that the combined incentives amount to nearly Rs 60,000-70,000 per vehicle.

While the draft policy had proposed incentives for strong hybrid vehicles, the final version excludes them. Defending the decision, Gupta said the government's immediate focus is on technologies that deliver the greatest environmental benefits. "This is an EV policy, not a petrol policy," Gupta said, adding that hybrids could be considered in future phases if cleaner technologies become more viable.

Learning from the shortcomings of the previous EV policy, Gupta said, the new policy has redesigned the subsidy disbursement mechanism. "Instead of routing benefits through dealerships, buyers will apply directly through a dedicated portal, with subsidy payments transferred into their bank accounts through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) within 60 days of vehicle registration," she said.

Acknowledging public concerns over inadequate charging facilities, Gupta said the government plans to expand Delhi's charging network from around 9,000 charging points to nearly 32,000 over the coming years.

Missiles

"Nobody could tell me what the merchant navy actually was," she recalls. "This blank space was my spark. I resolved to become the first person from my town to walk that path, so that anyone who came looking for answers afterwards could look at me, and I could show them exactly what's possible," she says.

With 3.23 lakh sailors (as of 2024), India ranks among the top three global suppliers of seafarers globally. Salim was one of the two women (the other being a deck cadet) amongst the crew of 24 on board her vessel as it drifted near the war zone.

Women however make up just 1% of the total number of seafarers globally. Salim was one of the two women (the other being a deck cadet) amongst the crew of 24 on board her vessel as it drifted near the war zone.

Terror list

In a notification, the Ministry of Home Affairs identified Saeed's close associates as Abdul Rauf, Hafiz Khalid Waleed and Rana Iftikhar. "Rana Iftikhar, 54, coordinates among anti-Jihadi organisations, motivates youths to carry out terrorist activities and is a close associate of Hafiz Saeed. Abdul Rauf, 52, belongs to LeT and Jamaat-ud-Dawa, is involved in planning and coordinating terrorist activities, collecting funds and is one of the main terrorists in LeT under the direct command of Hafiz Muhammad Saeed," the MHA said. Hafiz Khalid Waleed is associated with LeT and JuD. He is the son-in-law of Hafiz Mohammad Saeed and has been a member of the organisation's Central Advisory Committee since 2003. He was the mastermind behind the June 2016 Pampore attack, in which eight CRPF personnel were killed. He

was designated as a global terrorist by the US in August 2012.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah, in a post on X, said "Pursuing PM Shri Narendra Modi Ji's vision of zero tolerance against terror, the MHA today declared 23 dreaded terror functionaries affiliated with banned organisations as terrorists under the provisions of the UAPA. The designated terrorists are involved in anti-India activities, carrying out terror attacks, inciting terror, trafficking arms, infiltrating through the border, facilitating terrorist organisations, raising funds and recruiting terrorists. Out of the 23 terrorists announced today, 17 are Pakistani nationals and 6 are Indian nationals. However, all of them at present operate terrorist activities from Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir."

According to the MHA, formally designating these individuals as terrorists will not only help dismantle the terror ecosystem by curbing their financial networks, movements, re-

cruitment capabilities, and terror-linked activities, but will also send a strong message of deterrence against and terrorist acts.

It will also enhance the capacity of security and law enforcement agencies to initiate coordinated legal, investigative, and preventive actions at national and international levels.

Among those designated as terrorists is Masood Ilyas Kashmiri, also known as Mufti Masood Ilyas. The notification describes him as a 41-year-old man, currently residing in Rawalkot in Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir. He is a senior JeM functionary involved in recruiting youths, imparting training, and facilitating infiltration into India. The Centre has also linked him to the April 22, 2022 attack on security forces at Sunjwan in Jammu.

"Mohammad Mussadiq, also known as Doctor alias Hamza, a 38-year-old resident of Shakargarh in Narowal district of Pakistan, has also been designated. He is one of the main handlers of

JeM infiltration of Pakistani terrorists into J-K and was involved in the Sunjwan attack. He supplied arms and ammunition through drones across the border and is also involved in handling a team of JeM cyber players who use various social media platforms to recruit youths," the notification stated.

Fifty-two-year-old Mufti Muhammad Asghar Khan, also known as Abu Saad, a resident of Abbaspur in PoK, has also been listed. "He is a launching commander of JeM terrorists in J-K and one of the masterminds of the November 29, 2016, attack on the Indian Army camp at Nagrota in Jammu," the notification said.

The Centre has also designated as terrorist 56-year-old Hafiz Abdul Shakoor, who works as a launching commander for JeM in J-K and was involved in the 2016 Nagrota attack. Abdullah Jehadi, 47, also involved in the attack on the Indian Army camp at Nagrota, too has been listed.



UDAN next phase with Rs 29,000 cr outlay; PM opens Jodhpur terminal

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, July 4

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi launched the next phase of UDAN (Ude Desh ka Aam Nagrik) and inaugurated Jodhpur Airport's New Terminal Building (NTB) in Jodhpur Saturday.

On the occasion, Union Minister of Civil Aviation Ram Mohan Naidu Kinjarapu said that the launch of the Modified UDAN Scheme “marks the beginning of a new chapter in India’s aviation journey”. “Since 2016, UDAN has transformed the Prime Minister’s vision of ‘Hawai Chappal se Hawai Jahaz’ into a national movement by making air travel affordable, accessible and aspirational for every Indian,” he said.

Launched in October 2016, the UDAN Scheme has operationalised 669 routes and 95 airports, heliports and water aerodromes, covering over 1.66 crore passengers. This March, the Union Cabinet had approved the Modified UDAN Scheme with an outlay of approximately Rs 29,000 crore over the next ten years to accelerate aviation-led development.

The Modified UDAN Scheme focuses on expanding regional aviation infrastructure through the development of 100 aerodromes from existing unserved airstrips with an investment of Rs 12,159 crore. It



PM Narendra Modi, Civil Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu and Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma during the inauguration of the new terminal building of Jodhpur Airport on Saturday. PTI

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

ing of Rs 10,043 crore to sustain regional airline operations. The scheme also promotes the induction of indigenous aircraft and helicopters, including HAL Dhruv and Dornier platforms, for operations in underserved and remote regions.

Modi also inaugurated the New Terminal Building at Jodhpur Airport developed by the Airports Authority of India at a cost of Rs 480 crore. Spread across 23,342 square metres, the terminal is designed to handle 1,500 passengers during peak hours and 20 lakh passengers annually. It features 20 check-in counters, advanced security screening systems, modern baggage handling facilities and six aerobridges, ensuring a seamless passenger experience.

The newly developed apron can accommodate 11 A-321 aircraft and one ATR-72 aircraft, while the city-side infrastructure provides parking for approximately 320 cars, the government said.

Kinjarapu said that the new terminal "beautifully reflects the rich cultural and architectural heritage of Marwar. From its royal Rajasthani facade to interiors inspired by the region's vibrant traditions, the terminal will offer every passenger, especially visitors from across the world, their very first experience of Rajasthan's warmth and the spirit of 'Padhara Mhare Desh.'"

The existing terminal, with an annual capacity of about 4 lakh passengers, had reached saturation due to sustained traffic growth. "The new facility addresses future demand while incorporating sustainable features such as energy-efficient systems, water conservation measures and green building practices aimed at achieving a 5-Star GRIHA rating. Architecturally inspired by Rajasthan's royal heritage, the terminal blends traditional elements such as arches and jharokhas with contemporary design," the government said.

Modi opens chip facility in Gujarat, tells youth: 'idea *aapka*, *saath mera*'

Express News Service
Rajkot, July 4

"I SAID earlier this year that India will have four functional semiconductor factories in 2026 but today my Minister has said that there would be five. In the past six months alone, production has started in three facilities. Today's India has great ambitions and the strength to achieve them as well. India gives the same confidence and the same trust to investors as well. Our policies have stability. Our decisions have stability and progress has pace," PM Narendra Modi said in Sanand, Gujarat, on Saturday.

PM Modi was speaking at a ceremony to mark the commencement of commercial production of CG Semi Outsourced Semiconductor Assembly and Test (ISAT) facility in Sanand.

On his plans two decades ago, the PM said, "Around 20 years ago, or before, I made plans to set up a semiconductor plant in Gujarat. Identified 350-400 acres near Gandhinagar and Prantni and spoke to some companies. The Government was also talking about big things. But I don't know what happened and their (government) feet got shackled, and talks didn't proceed further. Today I see my 20-year-old dream, something that nobody

talked about at that time, today when it's happening, I have a lot of happiness."

"This is the third unit where commercial production of chip packaging is set to begin... This CG semiconductor plant is a result of cooperation between India, Japan, Thailand and other partners. It is not just a business venture it is a model of partnership that will give new impetus to India's semiconductor journey. I'm told 20 crore chips will be manufactured here each year ... I'm told you all have aimed at reaching 500 crore chips a year..."

He asked youths to make the most of the opportunities that semiconductor and AI were bringing to India. He said, "I want to tell the youth that whenever any new industrial revolution comes, the most opportunities are for the youth... Today is the era of semiconductor and AI, and these two are also bringing many opportunities. The need of the day is skill and new ideas. What matters today is whether you have a new idea or not. Whether you have the will to learn something new or not. The youth should not waste this opportunity and I tell you "idea aapka, saath mera."

The PM also congratulated the company for starting the OSAT facility in less than two and a half years.

AFTER DELAYED MONSOON, DELUGE

Low pressure system over Bay of Bengal brings promise of rain

Heavy rain likely in Maharashtra, Karnataka, MP

Express News Service
Bengaluru, July 4

THE SEASON'S first low pressure system, formed over the Bay of Bengal, will give a fillip to the monsoon and bring widespread rain over western and central India in the next 4 to 5 days.

"It (low pressure) is likely to move across north Odisha and north Chhattisgarh over the next 3 days," the Met department said on Saturday.

Kerala, coasts of Karnataka and Maharashtra, including Mumbai, Pune and nearby areas, have been receiving steady and heavy spells of rain since the past 2-3 days.

Low-lying areas in these cities witnessed flooding. Ghats of Madhya Maharashtra and Konkan reported over 200mm of rain on Friday. Parts of Saurashtra on Friday received 570mm of rain in 24 hours, submerging the area.

In addition to the low pressure, an off-shore trough runs between south Gujarat and Karnataka. This is adding to the favourable monsoon conditions over the western coast.

The IMD further said that monsoonal trough is active and is located to the south of its normal position.

Draft emission cut targets issued for iron, steel sector

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 4

THE CENTRE has once again issued a draft notification to set greenhouse gas emission intensity (GEI) targets for the intensive iron and steel sector and to align them under India's carbon credit trading system (CCTS).

The Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) issued the draft on June 26 and made it public on July 2. It has set emission reduction targets for 255 industrial units, including the sector's giants such as JSW Steel, Tata, SAIL (Steel Authority of India), and ArcelorMittal Nippon Steel, among others.

Draft targets for the iron and steel sector were already issued on June 23, 2025, along with aluminium (second aluminium), petroleum refinery, petrochemical and textile sectors. While final targets for other sectors were notified in January 2026, the Environment Ministry has issued a revised draft for iron and steel sector with marginal changes to targets, but without any explanation for the draft.

The draft notification lists 2023-24 as the year for baseline product output and baseline emission intensity, and 2026-27 as the compliance-year target for individual steel plants, sponge iron units and ferro-alloy manufacturers. A 60-day window has

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E. EXPLAINED

Global commitment on climate action

INDIA'S GLOBAL commitments on climate action include reducing emissions intensity of its GDP — emissions behind economic output — making heavy industry manufacturing cleaner and more efficient. The government has incentivised emissions reduction through a carbon credit scheme. As part of this initiative, it has set sectoral targets for more polluting industries. If industries achieve those targets, they can earn credits, or buy them from others.

been given to submit objections and suggestions on the draft.

The draft defined targets in terms of tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent (tCO₂e), which is used to measure the impact of all greenhouse gases and not just CO₂, based on their warming potential. The draft has set GEI targets only for 2026-27, while 2025-26 column has been left blank.

GEI is the amount of greenhouse gases (GHG) emitted per unit of product output, such as the quantum of gases released while producing cement. The

CCTS was launched in 2023 to create a framework that incentivises emission reduction through a market-based mechanism and to help achieve India's climate action goals.

The Centre has already finalised emission reduction targets for eight sectors — aluminium, cement, chlor-alkali, pulp and paper, secondary aluminium, petroleum refinery, petrochemical and textile.

In March, India revised its nationally determined contributions commitments on climate action under the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change and the Paris Agreement. This included a revision of target to reduce emissions intensity of Gross Domestic Product, which was set at 47% by 2035, compared to 2005 levels.

India has committed to reduce the emissions intensity of its gross domestic product — the amount of energy used per unit of GDP — to 47% by 2030 compared to 2005 levels as part of its domestic commitments under the agreement. The targets set in previous rounds covered 490 high-emission industrial units.

The CCTS, notified in 2023, created an overarching framework for the Indian carbon market. The objective was to slash or avoid GHG emissions from sectors whose processes emit more pollutants and whose operations are hard to decarbonise.

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own position that original guarantee remained operative. The NCLT relied on Everest Kento Cylinders Ltd v Union of India, quoting it as holding that a corporate guarantee "does not invalidate the original guarantee when additional security is sought" and that "the primary obligation secured by the guarantee remains enforceable."

Relying on this proposition, the NCLT held that "seeking additional guarantee does not invalidate the original Corporate Guarantee provided by the Corporate Debtor."

Essel's principal defence was that its liabilities, including the corporate guarantee, had shifted pursuant to a Bombay High Court-approved demerger and amalgamation in 2014. Reject-

ing this, NCLT relied on ICICI Bank Ltd v Urban Infrastructure Real Estate Ltd, quoting it as "a general corporate guarantee remains enforceable even if there is a restructuring of corporate structure, provided the underlying debt is not discharged."

The tribunal consequently held that the guarantee "will remain unaffected by the demerger & amalgamation." No such judgment exists.

Essel further argued that the bank could not proceed against it while insolvency proceedings were already underway against the principal borrower and Pan India Infraprojects Pvt Ltd, the entity to which the mortgaged property had eventually passed under the restructuring exercise. NCLT relied on Canara Bank

v N G Subbaraya Setty, quoting it as saying that "the rights of secured creditors over mortgaged or secured properties are not extinguished merely due to the transfer of such properties to another entity via amalgamation or restructuring."

Two other citations were relied upon to answer procedural objections. None of the six citations had been placed before the tribunal by either side. Jammu and Kashmir Bank, the financial creditor in the case, told the Supreme Court in an affidavit that its counsel had not cited any of the judgments and that the material appeared to have been sourced by the tribunal itself through its "own research."

FULL REPORT ON
[WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](https://www.indianexpress.com)

● ESSEL INFRAPROJECTS INSOLVENCY PROCEEDINGS IN CORPORATE GUARANTOR CASE

AI-hallucinated judgments: Why Supreme Court set aside a tribunal order

National Company Law Tribunal relied upon six AI-generated citations in ruling

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, July 4

SIX AI-HALLUCINATED judgments formed the basis for the Supreme Court's striking down of an order passed by the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) on Thursday.

Three of the cited judgments did not exist, while the remaining three either did not contain the propositions attributed to them or did not correspond to the context they were cited for.

For instance, the NCLT order cited a 2019 judgment ICICI Bank Ltd v Urban Infrastructure

Real Estate Ltd., which did not exist. Along with it, the 2021 case V S Dempo & Co Ltd v Reliance Communications Ltd and the 2022 case Sarbjit Singh v Union Bank of India were also found to be non-existent.

Two of the judgments, Everest Kento Cylinders Ltd v Union of India (2015) and Canara Bank v N G Subbaraya Setty (2018), were genuine, but the passages quoted from them are not found in the judgments themselves.

The sixth judgment, State Bank of India v M/s Shree Ram Urban Infrastructure Ltd, 2020 SCC OnLine SC 341, corre-

sponded to a different case, namely M Subramaniam v S Janaki, and the quoted passage does not appear there either.

The bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe observed on July 2 that while the use of AI judgments could be "gratifying, even inspiring," AI may eventually "infiltrate our intellectual work ethic and before long, render us dependent on its vast capabilities."

They said that "for those in the province of adjudication and determination of disputes, this by-product of AI, i.e., the production of fake, non-existent, and hallucinated material and its utilisation as precedents in law, is like the release of methyl isocyanate in the province of law and justice: invisible, insidious, and

catastrophic by the time anyone notices. It not only contaminates but takes away the very lifeblood of judicial determination."

Holding that a decision built on fabricated case law "is no decision at all," the court said such orders must be set aside even if "an iota of fake or hallucinated material enters the decision-making process."

The AI judgments

Six citations were relied upon by the NCLT while rejecting objections raised by Essel Infraprojects Ltd against insolvency proceedings initiated against it as a corporate guarantor.

One of Essel's arguments was that a renewal-cum-reduction letter issued by Jammu and Kashmir Bank in 2017 renewed

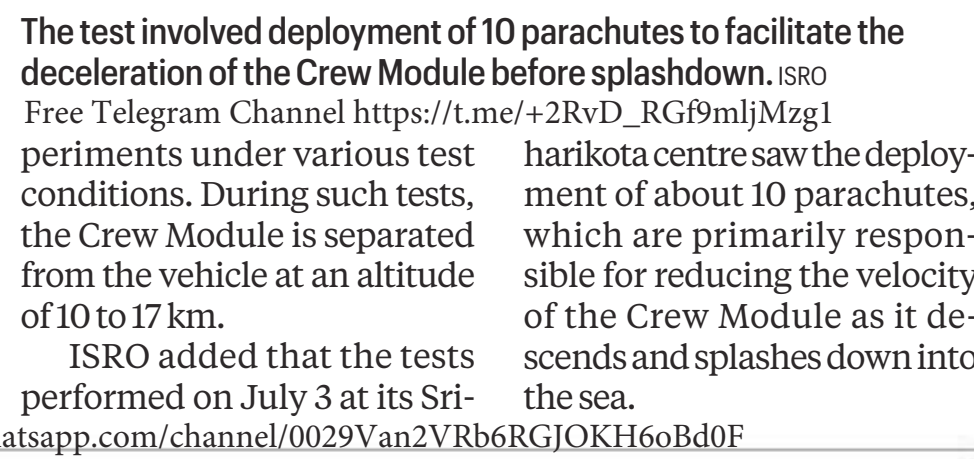
the loan on revised terms without mentioning the corporate guarantee, indicating that the guarantee had been relinquished. Rejecting this argument, the NCLT observed that "the said letter itself... states that all existing terms and conditions remain unchanged" and that the guarantee "remains valid and binding despite not being explicitly referenced in the renewal letter." For this reasoning, it relied on State Bank of India v. M/s Shree Ram Urban Infrastructure Ltd., quoting it as "the guarantor is bound by terms of guarantee as long as underlying debt is valid and enforceable."

Essel had also argued the bank's subsequent decision to obtain a fresh guarantee from another group undermined its

Express News Service
Bengaluru, July 4

This is a special test rocket that can perform numerous ex-

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Bring back the tigers that once roamed Mewar



AREFA TEHSIN

AFTER the Rajsamand MP’s statement opposing the proposed tiger reserve in Kumbhalgarh, a reactive skirmish has broken out. The MP, from the erstwhile royal family, has urged the Centre to drop the plan, stating that Kumbhalgarh “has never been a traditional tiger habitat”. The pushback is coming from erstwhile forest officers, some jagirdars of the former Mewar state. The tigers, one suspects, would twitch their whiskers on being told they had never actually been there. We, Mewaris, can’t take this as lightly.

Mewar stretches across south-central Rajasthan, from the Aravalli hills in the northwest to the Gujarat border in the south, and from Ajmer in the north to the Hadoti plateau in the east. Udaipur is its historic heart. The Kumbhalgarh forest was a royal hunting reserve. The right to hunt a tiger, notably, rested with the Maharana alone. Not other royals. Not the aristocracy. A leopard was fair game for the nobility, a tiger was not. A peer-reviewed paper in BT’s international journal (2022) by Bhanu Kapil and Uma Bhati of BN University, Udaipur, has dug into the Haqikat Bahidas — the official shikar diaries of the Mewar rulers — and found that in 1838-39, Maharana Sardar Singh was receiving regular field intelligence about tigers near Udaipur. His men came across them at Kamlod, Tikhlya, Urjankhura. The Rajputana Gazetteers of the Mewar Residency record tigers in the Aravallis “from Kumbhalgarh to Kotra”.

Sherlock Holmes had warned Watson: “It is a capital mistake to theorise before one has data. One begins to twist facts to suit theories, instead of theories to suit facts.” The data, in this case, is considerable. Jaswant Singh Nathawat, ex warden of Kumbhalgarh wildlife and park director of Ranthambore, has described in a video how he came across a tiger in Kumbhalgarh-Raoli Tatgarh sanctuary in 1967. My grandfather, T H Tehsin, later vice mayor of Udaipur, saw tigers in Mewar on several occasions. An archival register from the Raoli Forest Rest House in the Todgarh-Raoli Wildlife Sanctuary records tigers being shot from 1953 to 1955.

The concern about the Raika pastoral community and their camels is genuine, though it is worth noting that camels are not a tiger’s preferred quarry. The question of how a tiger reserve notification affects traditional grazing rights is one worth working through with the communities involved. It has a process; consultation, buffer zones, co-existence provisions, designed precisely because these situations are not new. We have navigated them in forests far more contested than Kumbhalgarh. It would be a pity to foreclose the conversation before it has properly begun.

There is also the question of what a tiger does to a landscape once it is back. Ecologists call it a keystone species, a polite way of saying its presence matters to things that have no obvious connection to tigers. Deer that know a predator is around don’t linger stripping a riverbank bare; they keep moving, nervously, which turns out to be rather good for the riverbank. The wolves of Yellowstone demonstrated this memorably. Kumbhalgarh’s wolves, leopards and hyenas lived alongside tigers for millennia. They did not find the arrangement disagreeable.

The Kumbhalgarh Wildlife Sanctuary, our family’s regular summer haunt since my childhood, is already a success story. Leopards, wolves, sloth bears, hyenas, jungle cats, golden jackals, caracals, honey badgers — it is almost like ticking off a field guide chapter. These forests predate British documentation. Many naturalists believe the terrain, cover, and prey base make it suitable for a tiger reintroduction. The region has historically been a tiger migration corridor from Gujarat through Panarwa to Jaisamand into Madhya Pradesh. What’s missing is not the habitat. It is the tiger, and that is a human doing, not an ecological verdict. The Aravallis of Mewar housed tigers, then lost them fairly recently, and seem to be in adequate shape for a second chance. Whether they get one is, as usual, less a question of ecology than of who is inconvenienced by the answer.

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Tehsin, former honorary wildlife warden, Udaipur, is the author, most recently, of The Great Indian Safari

RELIANCE ON SHORT-TERM FIXES MAY BE A WORRY FOR BANKS

Amid slowing CASA growth, banks turn to costly solutions

Akash Mandal
New Delhi, July 4

Credit growth has picked up over the past few months, but banks have struggled to grow their deposit base to match it.

Growth in current account and savings account (CASA) deposits has particularly slowed, with retail investors now having a range of avenues to put their savings in, such as stocks and mutual funds. These avenues provide much better returns than traditional CASA accounts and have become more accessible over time due to digitisation and regulatory bodies' simplification of norms. CASA deposits are low-cost for banks and are used to fund loans, the major source of revenue.

They are considered a reliable and "sticky" source of funds for banks due to low churn, as such depositors aren't likely to shift this money to other banks easily.

Due to this mismatch in growth, the gap between credit and deposit growth has widened from 1.8 percentage points in December to 5.4 percentage points as of June 15, according to data from the RBI.

This has led to the credit-to-deposit ratio of banks — which is the percentage of a bank's deposits deployed as loans — widening to 82.5% as of June 15 from around 75% in mid-2025. The slowdown was also noted in the Reserve Bank of India's Financial Stability Report released last week.



CASA deposits are low-cost for banks and are used to fund loans, the major source of revenue. REUTERS

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Banks shifting to other funding avenues

As CASA deposits have slowed, banks have shifted to other sources of funds such as term deposits and CDs.

Term deposits refer to financial instruments where one locks in their money for a particular tenure to earn interest in return. This includes retail options such as fixed and recurring deposits. A CD is a type of term deposit used by corporates and institutions to raise money through the money markets.

"CASA is the low-cost liability available to banks. Additionally, on a behavioural pattern perspective, CASA can support creation of longer-tenure assets. CDs, on the other hand, have historically been used to manage shorter-dur-

ation liquidity by banks," said Rohan Mandora, associate director at Equirus Securities.

As a result, the share of CASA in the total deposit base of the banking system has fallen to around 39% from a peak of around 44% in FY22 (during the post-Covid liquidity boom). Meanwhile, the share of term deposits has inched up to all-time highs of over 61% from around 56% in FY23.

Why is it a concern

CASA deposits have always been a reliable funding source for banks due to their low cost (around 3-4% interest rate) and "stickiness". Term deposits and CDs, on the other hand, are much higher-cost (7-8% interest rate) options that ultimately squeeze the margins of banks. "CDs are wholesale, price-

• LOAN VS DEPOSIT

THE GAP between credit and deposit growth has widened from 1.8 percentage points in December to 5.4 percentage points as of June 15

THIS HAS led to the credit-to-deposit ratio of banks — which is the percentage of a bank's deposits deployed as loans — widening to 82.5% as of June 15 from around 75% in mid-2025

RBI, IN its Financial Stability Report released last week, also took note of the slowdown

sensitive money with typical tenors of 3-12 months, whereas CASA is granular, behaviourally sticky retail money. In a tight-liquidity phase, CD roll-over costs can spike quickly," said Yuvraj Choudhary, research analyst at Anand Rathi Institutional Equities. While banks have largely managed to maintain robust financial growth and protect their net-interest margins (NIM) so far, this increased reliance on higher-cost shorter-term funds has already started to seep in. The impact has been limited due to the low interest rate environment. This rate influences the interest rates across the entire banking system. During a low interest rate cycle, banks are able to offer lower rates to depositors, providing some breathing space.

"On funding costs, the pressure is visible but contained. The current rate-cut cycle works in banks' favour. CDs and bulk term deposits re-price downward the fastest, so short-term wholesale reliance is cheapest to carry precisely now. The risk flips when the rate cycle turns," said Choudhary. "Incrementally, some banks have marginally increased their term deposit rates in Q1. We expect the impact of higher share of bulk deposits to flow into cost of funds during 2H FY27," according to Mandora. Experts also believe the sluggish CASA growth is cyclical in nature after the post-Covid boom in liquidity due to steps by the central bank. "We believe this is more cyclical in nature and linked to overall liquidity in the system.

With most banks showing little difference in asset quality, liability franchise quality is becoming the key competitive moat in Indian banking," an analyst at a domestic firm said.

Thus, while banks have found shorter-term funding solutions as CASA growth has dried up, the over-reliance on such temporary fixes is a double-edged sword.

While it helps manage liquidity and fund the booming credit growth for now, a hike in interest rates by the RBI or an external crisis may hit the sector hard if CASA growth is not rejuvenated.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Skyroot co-founder: India's aerospace industry is taking a private turn with ISRO's help

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, July 4

INDIA'S AEROSPACE industry is "very encouraging" to private players, with ISRO and private companies developing a relationship which is similar to NASA and SpaceX in the US, Skyroot Aerospace co-founder Pawan Kumar Chandana told *The Indian Express*.

On June 2, Skyroot announced they will launch an orbital class rocket, Vikram-1, into space within a window of July 12 to August 4.

Skyroot is a private space launch company. In 2022, Skyroot launched India's first private satellite — Vikram-S — from ISRO's facilities.

Vikram-1 is designed to deploy small satellites of up to 350-kg to low Earth orbit. Built with an all-carbon composite structure and powered by solid and liquid propulsion systems — including 3D printed engines — developed by Skyroot, Vikram is going to be a successful flight, its makers say.

"At Skyroot, we already launched Vikram-S from ISRO's launch pad. That was a suborbital launch. Now we are getting ready for India's first private orbital launch. It is the first test flight. There is also an expression of interest released with regard to the Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (SSLV), Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV) and Launch Vehicle Mark-3 (LVM-3) by the government of India.

So that private companies can take ISRO's vehicles and operate them. We will see more and more of this kind of collaboration in India," Chandana said. India's space economy is expected to grow from around \$8.4 billion now to \$44 billion by 2033.

Indigenous launch capability will be a critical enabler of this growth, unlocking opportunities for India's rapidly expanding private space ecosystem, Skyroot believes.

Vikram-1's test flight is im-

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Skyroot launched India's first private satellite, Vikram-S, from ISRO's facilities in 2022.

PHOTO: X/@PAWANKCHANDANA

portant because the ability to reach orbit reliably and frequently is a strategic capability that only a handful of nations have. Today, access to space remains a major bottleneck, with satellite operators often waiting months or even years for a launch opportunity.

"ISRO has been amazingly supportive. Their support has been excellent. What more they can do is that in whatever ISRO is doing, in their missions of national importance, they can have private startups as development partners. We could co-build some of the systems which ISRO would use — whether it be the space stations, new satellites they are developing or new rockets they are developing. We would like to be a more integral part of ISRO's developments making the ecosystem more sustainable, so that the startups would have revenue opportunities and ISRO would benefit from the startups' feed and energy," Chandana said.

The first flight would capture the real in-flight performance data from every system on Vikram-1. This will help the makers understand how the ve-

hicle performs from lift-off through every phase of ascent. "This data cannot be fully replicated through ground testing," Chandana said.

He added, "It is the first time in India that a private company has designed and developed a rocket meant to launch a satellite to space. This was enabled by the recent set of reforms by the government of India which opened up the sector to private players. We are completely designed, developed and manufactured rocket is going to take off from Indian soil. The rocket will have the capability to launch satellites to orbit. And in the entire world there are only a few companies with this capability. So it is a venture with a lot of business potential and also strategic importance for the country because we have the capability to launch more of our satellites to space".

Skyroot sees potential in the market because, "globally only two players who are regularly launching to space — one is SpaceX and another is Rocket Lab". "There are two or three other companies that have started their launches just like us but almost all of them are from the US. There are a couple of companies from China as well but access to the market is domestic for them. This will inspire other startups to come. Take the example of SpaceX, which has inspired others to come into the field. Similarly, we will also inspire others to venture into the field with unique solutions and differentiators," Chandana said.

The launch is called Mission Aagaman, meaning "the arrival" and it marks Skyroot's second mission following the successful suborbital flight of Vikram-S, the first private rocket to reach space from Indian soil, Chandana said.

Vikram-1 will be a partially commercial flight, with the company planning to commence full commercial flights after one or two successful demonstrations to orbit.

India-Israel bilateral investment agreement comes into effect

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, July 4

THE INDIA-Israel Bilateral Investment Agreement (BIA), which will ensure a secure and predictable investment climate between the two countries, came into force from Saturday, the finance ministry said.

The pact, which will provide protection to the two-way investments, is expected to contribute to increased cross-border investment activity.

The two countries inked the treaty on September 8 last year.

Under the pact, India has cut down the local remedies exhaustion period for Israeli investors to three years.

Local remedies exhaustion means that investors must first try to resolve their disputes using the legal system of the host country before they can take the matter to international arbitration. Normally, India keeps a five-year period for this.

The India-Israel BIA also includes portfolio investments in a deviation from such treaties in the past.

Israel is the first OECD (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development) member with which India has inked this agreement.

The agreement is expected to pave the way for increased bilateral investments between the two countries. During April 2000 and March 2026, India received \$371.35 million foreign direct investment (FDI) from Israel.

The implementation of the pact is important as both countries are also negotiating a free trade pact. The negotiations for the trade pact are going slow due to the West Asia crisis. India is also negotiating bilateral investment treaties with other countries, including Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Oman, Switzerland, Russia, Australia and the European Union.

These investment treaties help in protecting and promoting investments in each other's countries. The government has earlier announced revamping the current model of BITs to make it more investor-friendly and attract foreign players.

Commenting on the pact, think tank GTRI said the 2015 model text treaty has excluded portfolio investments, while the Israel agreement covers shares, stocks and other equity holdings, as well as qualifying bonds, loans and other corporate debt.

"This could widen India's exposure to investor-state disputes beyond traditional foreign direct investment to certain financial investments," GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said. He said the Israel pact allows investors to seek international arbitration after pursuing domestic legal remedies.

● THE FINDINGS INCLUDE 11 ROCK-CUT TOMBS, WITH AN AVERAGE DEPTH OF 8 METRES, AND SEVEN SURFACE LIMESTONE-BUILT TOMBS

Well preserved: Egypt uncovers lost Byzantine-era city in the western desert

Samy Magdy
Cairo, July 4

A WELL-PRESERVED Byzantine-era residential city in the western desert is one of two major archaeological finds announced by Egypt on Saturday. The recent discoveries at the Dakhla Oasis and at the Marina el-Alamein archaeological site, near Alexandria, are the latest findings which the Egyptian government hopes will boost the country's vital tourism sector, partially driven by antiquities sightseeing. Along with the strategic Suez Canal, tourism is a major source of foreign currency in the cash-strapped country.

The Tourism and Antiquities Ministry said that the first discovery reveals details of daily life, urban development and economic activities in the Dakhla Oasis in the fourth century, when Egypt was part of the Byzantine empire. The unearthed quarters included north-south thoroughfares intersected by east-west streets, forming open squares and public spaces, said Hisham el-Leithy, secretary general of the supreme council of antiquities. A basilica church, dating back to the mid-fourth century, stands at the settlement's head, overlooking its main streets, along with remains of two watchtowers to safeguard

the outskirts, said Mahmoud Massoud, who chairs the archaeological mission. The oasis, located in Egypt's western province of New Valley in the western desert, is on UNESCO's Tentative List, a step away from being added to the agency's World Heritage List. A heavily fortified structure with thick defensive walls, and many houses consisting of reception halls and vaulted roofs were found in the area, Massoud said. Among them were the house of Tisous, identified as a church deacon and dating to the second half of the fourth century, which archaeologists believe served as a house church before the construction



It is located in Egypt's western province of New Valley
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of the city's basilica. Archaeologists also uncovered bread ovens, kitchens and stone grinding tools that had been apparently used to produce food. Also found were well-preserved bronze coins bearing portraits of Byzantine

emperors, Latin inscriptions and Christian symbols, alongside a group of gold coins dating to the reign of Roman emperor Constantius II, who ruled between 337 and 361, the ministry statement said. Diaa Zahran, head of the Islamic, Coptic and Jewish Antiquities department, said they found a collection of about 200 pottery fragments which would have been used as writing material. The fragments, known as ocraca, have inscriptions detailing commercial transactions, correspondence and other details of daily life, Zahran said. Separately, archaeologists have found 18 ancient tombs in the Marina el-Alamein archaeological site, which is around 100 kilometers (62 miles) west of the Mediterranean city of Alexandria. The findings included 11 rock-cut tombs, with an average depth of 8 meters, and seven surface limestone-built tombs, the ministry said. That has brought the total tombs found in the site to 48, ministry said. In the site, archaeologists found pottery vessels, amphorae, lamps, plates, altars and limestone basins, it said. Mission chief Eman Abdel-Khaliq said they found a 2.5-meter-long granite sarcophagus, with skeleton remains that were currently being studied. Close to the sarcophagus, they

found the remains of a plaster sphinx statue, she said. Abdel-Khaliq said they also found 4 gold pieces placed inside the mouths of some of the deceased — known as “the golden tongue,” which had been a practice associated with funerary beliefs of that era. Marina el-Alamein is an archaeological site close to the city of Alamein in Egypt's Northern Coast. Unearthed in 1986, archaeologists believe that the site was the ancient Greco-Roman port city of Leukaspis on the Mediterranean, which was built in the second century and thrived until the fourth century, the ministry said.

AP